KATTAR KINNAR
Kinari

Formerly known as Finsta, rapper Kinari combines the flamboyant sexuality of *mujra* and ballroom dance with the rough rhythms of North Chennai *gaana* and the hazy belligerence of contemporary New Delhi trap. Over producer Nasbandi's sparse, moody compositions, Kinari raps in explicit, softly sinister rhymes about life as a Tamil trans woman in New Delhi, with its sultry joys and grimy material struggles. Steeped in a strong, thoughtfully enunciated critique of mainstream Indian society, *Kattar Kinnar* is an explicit portrayal of queer life and love, unrestrained by the straight gaze or notions of 'respectability'.

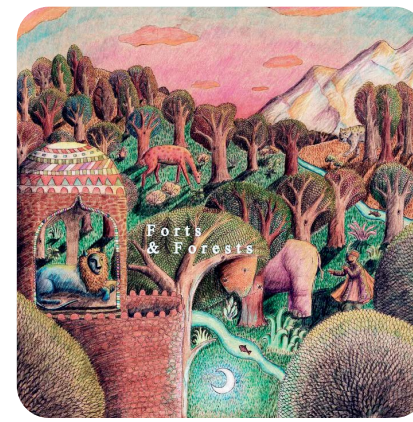


SATURN RETURN
Dee En



On their upcoming EP *Saturn Return*, New Delhi band Dee En trades the jangly guitars and fuzzy psychedelia of their earlier work for cosmic grooves and gleaming synths. The EP's six tracks draw from contemporary hip-hop and 1980s electronica to craft a cosmic new sound with the slickness and sophistication of space-age pop. Disco synths and glitchy percussion of opener 'Darling' are anchored to the ground by guest musician Rohit Gupta's earthy trumpet, while Sijya contributes her ethereal voice to the shimmering club-pop of 'Troglodyte', songs that—like the rest of the EP—reference Saturn's 30-year-trip around the sun as a metaphor for the journey from birth to adulthood.

FORTS AND FORESTS
Khus Fir



An alumnus of Bengaluru's forward-thinking indie-electronic label and collective *Consolidate*, Rishabh Iyer (aka Khus Fir) already has a reputation for defying categories. He continues in the same vein on the independently released *Forts and Forests*, its 10 tracks incorporating Indian folk percussion, hand-picked acoustic guitar and warbling electronics into a sound that belongs nowhere and everywhere. Over it all soars Rishabh's voice, occasionally crooning, occasionally in a Bob Dylan-esque drawl, always enchanting.

–Bhanuj Kappal

(Below left) Rajarshi Sanyal; IP Singh



Ke Na Jaa' with Raghav Chaitanya, among others. As always, their soft spot for collaborations takes centrestage in this EP. "Every time such versatile artists come on board, they bring their unique character and soul to our tracks. Their voice has helped to take our music to a new dimension," says Singh.

Between their last album in 2014, *Phir Se*, and now, the musicians released several singles, including the chartbuster 'Nasha' in collaboration with Amar Jalal, later featured in Ayushmann Khurrana's *An Action Hero*. "Previously, people were listening to singles and making their playlists. With the Covid-19 lockdown, more attention was paid to new music. Today, albums are gradually making a comeback with people listening to music in longer stretches. We thought it was the right time to release this collection of tracks," adds Sanyal.

Ibtida includes tracks with singers Jubin Nautiyal and Raghav Chaitanya, among others

Thus, it's almost fitting that *Ibtida* also translates into 'new beginnings'. "We would also like to dedicate this EP to our new studio that we opened this year in Mumbai. It's a happy, warm space to create music," mentions Singh.

After 2014, the duo moved to Mumbai and admit it took them some time to adapt. "It was exciting and scary at the same time and took up a lot of our energy. We are comfortable where we are, and are hoping to release more albums," says Singh. ■

–Geetika Sachdev